lands in Western Francia bordered Louis's own. But it is hard to imagine that Louis did not feel some personal pique against the man who had succeeded where he had failed.

The constant squabbles between the English and the French kings had been temporarily smoothed over by Henry's agreement, in 1169, to divide his lands in Western Francia among his three elder sons: Henry the Younger got Anjou and Maine; Geoffrey got Brittany; Richard, his mother's favorite, was awarded the Duchy of Aquitaine. (John got nothing, earning him the derisive nickname "John Lackland.") This broke up the united English front facing Louis, but he was not yet satisfied, particularly since Henry kept his fist closed tight over his sons. He was, says Gerald of Wales, "the kindest of fathers . . . during their childhood and youth, but as they advanced in years looked on them with an evil eye. . . he could never bear to think of them as his successors." The French lands were theirs in name, but Henry ran their domains for them.[5]

Louis, who had betrothed the daughter of his second marriage to Henry the Younger as part of a peace deal, was undoubtedly aware of this state of affairs; he played on Henry's natural resentments. He suggested to young Henry, privately, that he ask for the right to rule part of his father's domain independently: Normandy or Anjou, perhaps. Or, failing that, England itself.[6]

Henry II refused, curtly (and not unreasonably). And so Henry the Younger ran away from home. "He seethed and growled against his father," writes William of Newburgh, "and secretly took refuge with his father-in-law the king of France, intending to cause his father annoyance." When Henry II sent a message to Louis VII, demanding that his son return home, Louis VII retorted, "The king of England is here, and gives no instruction to me."[7]

This was a clear statement of war on Louis's part and treason on young Henry's, and the English barons immediately began to take sides. A good number of them defected to the rebellious son's side; Henry, an authoritarian and controlling king, had made enemies. "Those men who joined the party of the son," writes the contemporary historian Ralph of Diceto, "[did so] not because they regarded his as the juster cause, but because the father . . . was trampling upon the necks of the proud and haughty, [and] was dismantling or appropriating the castles of the country."[8]

They were shortly joined by Henry's younger brothers, Geoffrey and Richard.

Eleanor herself, who was at Poitiers with her sons when the revolt began, seems to have encouraged her sons to rebel against their father. She and Henry had been on increasingly poor terms since Becket's murder; and Henry